

Chapter 2

The Pieces That Never Fit

The front door slammed shut.

Elara rushed upstairs without saying a word. She entered her room and locked the door behind her.

Click.

The silence was unbearable.

For a few moments, she simply stood there, staring at the floor.

Then everything inside her broke.

Tears streamed down her face as she covered her mouth, trying to hold back the pain.

"It can't be..."

Roman.

He was alive.

The face she had hated for three years...

The face she believed belonged to a murderer.

Her breathing became uneven.

She grabbed the books from her desk and threw them across the room.

One after another.

A glass frame crashed onto the floor, scattering broken pieces everywhere.

She sank to her knees.

No..."

"I buried you in my hatred three years ago."

"So why are you back?"

Her voice trembled.

"I hated you for three years..."

She closed her eyes tightly.

Then why... why does my heart refuse to hate you?

As she tried to calm herself, something beneath the broken glass caught her attention.

A small silver bracelet.

Her hands froze.

Slowly, she picked it up.

The bracelet...

Roman had given it to her on the night everything changed.

A faint memory flashed before her eyes.

The evening sky was painted with shades of orange as a cool breeze brushed through Elara's dark brown wavy hair.

Roman stood in front of her with a small smile, gently placing the silver bracelet in her hand.

"For luck," he said softly.

Elara looked at it and chuckled.

"I don't even wear bracelets."

"I know."

"Then why are you giving me one?"

Roman smiled, his eyes never leaving hers.

"Keep it."

"One day, when we're older..."

"You'll laugh remembering tonight."

Elara rolled her eyes with a smile and slipped the bracelet into her pocket.

"You're weird."

"But you still kept it," Roman laughed.

The memory vanished as quickly as it had appeared, leaving only silence behind.....

Elara's eyes flew open.

Her breathing became heavy as she stared at the bracelet in her trembling hand.

"No..."

She whispered.

"If that night started like this..."

"What happened after that?"

The room was silent. Only the sound of rain tapping against the window filled the darkness.

Outside, rain slowly began tapping against her bedroom window.

And for the first time in three years...

Elara wasn't sure if the person she hated was really the villain.

Elara stared at the bracelet for a long time.

Her thumb slowly traced its smooth silver surface.

Three years.

She had kept it for three years.

Not because she wanted to...

But because she had never found the courage to throw it away.

A faint smile, filled with pain, crossed her lips.

"I should've gotten rid of you long ago..."

She whispered.

"So why couldn't I?"

No answer came.

Only the rain continued to fall outside.

She slowly walked toward the window.

The city lights blurred behind the raindrops.

Everything felt distant.

Everything felt unreal.

Roman was alive.

The thought echoed inside her mind over and over again.

She closed her eyes, taking a slow breath.

"I don't know who you are anymore..."

"...and I don't know who I've become."

For a long moment, she stood there without moving.

Then she carefully placed the bracelet inside the drawer beside her bed.

She switched off the light.

Darkness swallowed the room.

Outside...

The rain continued to fall.

Inside...

Neither the storm outside nor the one inside her heart showed any sign of ending.

The next morning...

Soft rays of sunlight slipped through the curtains, gently lighting the room.

Elara lay awake on her bed, staring silently at the ceiling.

She hadn't slept.

Not even for a minute.

A gentle knock broke the silence.

"Elara?"

Her mother's voice came from outside.

"It's morning, sweetheart."

No answer.

Slowly, the door opened.

The moment she stepped inside, she stopped.

Books were scattered across the floor.

A broken photo frame lay beside the bed, surrounded by shattered glass.

The room looked as if a storm had passed through it.

Her eyes finally found Elara.

She was lying quietly on the bed, her dark brown wavy hair spread across the pillow.

Dark circles rested beneath her beautiful brown eyes.

She looked exhausted.

Her mother sat beside her and gently brushed a few strands of hair away from her face.

"You didn't sleep..."

Elara forced a weak smile.

"I'm okay."

Her mother knew she wasn't.

But instead of asking questions, she softly kissed Elara's forehead.

"Come downstairs."

"You need to eat something."

After a few minutes, Elara slowly got ready.

As she reached for the door, her eyes briefly fell on the bedside drawer.

She looked away without opening it.

Taking a deep breath, she walked downstairs.

The smell of breakfast filled the house.

As she entered the dining room...

She stopped.

Ethan was already sitting at the table.

He looked up and smiled politely.

"Good morning, Elara."

For a moment...

Neither of them spoke.

The breakfast table had long been cleared.

The house was quiet.

Elara stepped out into the garden, hoping the fresh air would calm the storm inside her.

She sat on the wooden bench, her fingers absentmindedly tracing the edge of the seat.

A few moments later...

Ethan walked over.

"There you are," he said with a small smile.

"Mind if I join you?"

Elara nodded.

For a while...

Neither of them spoke.

The wind gently rustled the leaves above them.

Finally...

Elara broke the silence.

"Ethan..."

"Hm?"

She kept her eyes fixed on the ground.

"I've been thinking about something."

"What is it?"

After a brief pause, she asked quietly,

"Three years ago..."

"You told me Roman was dead."

Ethan's expression didn't change.

"Yes."

Elara slowly turned to look at him.

"How were you so sure?"

For the first time...

Ethan hesitated.

Only for a second.

"I..."

He looked away before answering.

"After everything that happened that night..."

"He disappeared."

"No one could find him."

"Everyone believed he was dead."

Elara frowned.

"So..."

"You never actually saw his body?"

Silence.

Ethan tightened his grip around the coffee cup.

"...No."

Elara looked at him for a long moment.

Then she quietly looked away again.

"I was just wondering."

A faint smile appeared on Ethan's face.

"You should stop thinking about him."

"He belongs to the past."

Elara didn't answer.

But somewhere deep inside...

That answer didn't feel right anymore.

Days turned into weeks.

But nothing changed.

The sleepless nights remained.

So did the unanswered questions.

No matter how hard Elara tried to move on...

Roman's face refused to leave her mind.

His eyes.

His voice.

That unexpected meeting.

Everything haunted her in silence.

Unable to escape the chaos inside her, Elara buried herself in work.

A few days later...

She officially joined her father's company.

She believed work would distract her.

She had no idea...

It would pull her even closer to the truth.